NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER

VOLUME V

Blood and Chains

The Null-Cages. The Dark Labyrinth. The Sigil Realm. Companions branded. Corruption risk.

Age Rating: 15+ | Dark Epic Fantasy | First Edition

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Prologue

The Null-Cage Reports

Something has been capturing people of power -- not killing them. Caging them. The cages are made of nothing.

Alexa was beside him. She was always beside him. She had the expression she wore when something significant was approaching -- not alarm, not battle-readiness, but a particular quality of attention, her grey-depth eyes fixed on a middle distance that was more than physical space. He had learned to trust that expression.

Alexa moved through the space with the dual awareness she always carried -- present in the immediate world as a shadow-beast, as a bonded companion, as a creature whose senses extended into registers that Nicholas's did not -- and simultaneously present in the shared awareness of the bond, the ongoing conversation of feeling and attention that ran between them without words. He felt what she felt. She felt what he felt. This had stopped being strange and had become simply the way he understood his environment.

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Chapter I

Into the Eastern Passes

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The shadow compass was in his hand. The needle was steady. He held it for a moment, this object that had been pointing at things for months, that had never yet pointed at the wrong thing, that had asked him to trust it repeatedly and had been worth trusting. Then he put it away. The needle would move when it was ready. Until then, this place. These people. This work.

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Chapter IV

Mikaela's War

The powerful Spanish-heritage arcane duelist who has been fighting the Null-Cage phenomenon for a month, alone.

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Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

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Chapter V

Eugenia

The hidden genius who has been inside a Null-Cage, studied it from the inside, and escaped. She has notes.

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Chapter VII

The Dark Labyrinth

The Sigil Realm's interior -- a maze of branded walls, shifting corridors, and sigils that activate when read.

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The shadow compass was in his hand. The needle was steady. He held it for a moment, this object that had been pointing at things for months, that had never yet pointed at the wrong thing, that had asked him to trust it repeatedly and had been worth trusting. Then he put it away. The needle would move when it was ready. Until then, this place. These people. This work.

~ * ~

Chapter VIII

The Blood Trial Part II

The Labyrinth IS the Blood Trial. Everyone is branded by the time they get out.

Laura's briefing had been characteristically thorough. She had laid out the parameters, the known variables, the estimated unknowns, and the decision tree she had prepared for each scenario. Nicholas had listened to all of it and then said: what is the thing you could not put in the briefing? She had looked at him for a moment. Then she had told him.

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Laura's floating apparatus glowed at three-quarter power -- the setting she used for active situations that had not yet resolved into full engagement. He had learned her apparatus's power levels the way you learned a person's facial expressions: as a reliable indicator of her assessment of the current situation. Three-quarter meant: significant, developing, not yet critical, stay ready.

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The Shadow rose briefly in his hands -- not called, not needed, just present, the shadow-element responding to the quality of his attention the way it always did. He let it settle. The Guardian Trial had changed his relationship to the power: it was no longer something he managed, something he was careful with, something he monitored for the risk of it overflowing. It was simply his. It was what he was. The management had been replaced by inhabitation.

Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

~ * ~

Chapter IX

Dark Powers Inventory

Each companion catalogues what they now carry. The room is quiet for a long time.

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The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded dark powers inventory, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

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When it was over -- when this chapter of things had reached its conclusion and the next one had not yet begun -- Nicholas stood in the space it had left and felt what was there. Not triumph. Not relief, though relief was present. The specific feeling of having done what was needed to be done, of having been the right configuration of people in the right place at the right time, of the piece moving into

its correct position in the larger structure that none of them could see all of at once but that the compass pointed toward, always, faithfully, toward whatever came next.

~ * ~

Chapter X

Andrea

A fierce elemental brawler found at the Labyrinth's edge, fighting her way through a wall. She joins.

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its correct position in the larger structure that none of them could see all of at once but that the compass pointed toward, always, faithfully, toward whatever came next.

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Chapter XI

Corruption Risk

Two companions begin showing signs of their dark power consuming rather than supplementing. Nicholas must act.

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The Shadow rose briefly in his hands -- not called, not needed, just present, the shadow-element responding to the quality of his attention the way it always did. He let it settle. The Guardian Trial had changed his relationship to the power: it was no longer something he managed, something he was careful with, something he monitored for the risk of it overflowing. It was simply his. It was what he was. The management had been replaced by inhabitation.

The shadow compass was in his hand. The needle was steady. He held it for a moment, this object that had been pointing at things for months, that had never yet pointed at the wrong thing, that had asked him to trust it repeatedly and had been worth trusting. Then he put it away. The needle would move when it was ready. Until then, this place. These people. This work.

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Chapter XII

Purification

Nicholas learns what the shadow-element can do for someone who has been consumed by their dark power. It costs something.

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Chapter XIII

The Curse Arc Begins

Dimitreus's counter-move: a curse that makes companions forget who they are. The first symptoms appear.

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Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

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Chapter XIV

What Shadow Remembers

The shadow-power has a memory function -- it can hold who someone is and reflect it back when they forget.

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The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded what shadow remembers, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

Alexa moved through the space with the dual awareness she always carried -- present in the immediate world as a shadow-beast, as a bonded companion, as a creature whose senses extended into registers that Nicholas's did not -- and simultaneously present in the shared awareness of the bond, the ongoing conversation of feeling and attention that ran between them without words. He felt what she felt. She felt what he felt. This had stopped being strange and had become simply the way he understood his environment.

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Chapter XV

The Sigil Scholar

Ksu deciphers the Labyrinth sigils. What they spell, read in order, is a message. An old message. From before the shatter.

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Chapter XVI

Breaking the Cage System

How to dismantle a Null-Cage from the outside -- Soreen and Bogdan and a great deal of improvisation.

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The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded breaking cage system, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

Alexa moved through the space with the dual awareness she always carried -- present in the immediate world as a shadow-beast, as a bonded companion, as a creature whose senses extended into registers that Nicholas's did not -- and simultaneously present in the shared awareness of the bond, the ongoing conversation of feeling and attention that ran between them without words. He felt what she felt. She felt what he felt. This had stopped being strange and had become simply the way he understood his environment.

The group had a rhythm now that was different from the rhythm they had when they left Ashenveil. Different from the rhythm they had after Vieau, after the Archipelago, after the void and the return. Each stage of the journey had added something to how they moved together -- an additional layer of trust, an additional refinement of how they divided labor and shared information and made decisions under pressure. They were better at this than they had ever been. They were not done getting better.

Laura's floating apparatus glowed at three-quarter power -- the setting she used for active situations that had not yet resolved into full engagement. He had learned her apparatus's power levels the way you learned a person's facial expressions: as a reliable indicator of her assessment of the current situation. Three-quarter meant: significant, developing, not yet critical, stay ready.

Rominae was at the edge of whatever space they occupied, which was where Rominae always positioned herself -- not separate from the group, but at its margin, where the soul-sight had the widest field and where the dark magic had the most room to operate without interfering with the lighter elements in the group's center. She had not said what she was seeing. When she had something actionable, she would say so. Until then, she watched.

The shape of what was required was becoming clearer. Not clear yet -- this was still the middle of the middle, the part of the story where you had enough information to understand what you did not know but not enough to understand what you needed to know. He had learned to be patient with this stage. The clarity came when it came. Trying to force it produced false clarity, which was worse than uncertainty.

Bogdan was documenting. He was always documenting. At some point the notebooks had multiplied to the point where he carried a secondary pack specifically for them, and the documentation had become so comprehensive that Laura had integrated it into her strategic planning, requesting specific data points before briefings with the efficiency of someone who had realised that Bogdan's documentation was not a personal habit but a collective resource.

Ksu was drawing on her left forearm -- the preparation sigil that she always drew before a situation resolved, the one whose duration was long enough to carry through whatever came next. She had told him once that the preparation sigil was not for power but for presence: it helped her stay in her body, stay in her skill, stay in the specific consciousness of someone who worked with living ink and needed to be fully in contact with the work. He had understood that immediately.

Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

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Epilogue

Dimitreus Feels the Wounding

The Curse Arc, if broken, will wound him. He knows this. He does not stop it. He is curious what they will do.

Nicholas stood at whatever threshold marked the end of this chapter of things and looked back at what they had come through. He did this occasionally -- not often, not with nostalgia, but with the specific purpose of understanding what the path had been before moving onto the next section of it.

The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded dimitreus feels wounding, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

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Ksu was drawing on her left forearm -- the preparation sigil that she always drew before a situation resolved, the one whose duration was long enough to carry through whatever came next. She had told him once that the preparation sigil was not for power but for presence: it helped her stay in her body, stay in her skill, stay in the specific consciousness of someone who worked with living ink and needed to be fully in contact with the work. He had understood that immediately.

When it was over -- when this chapter of things had reached its conclusion and the next one had not yet begun -- Nicholas stood in the space it had left and felt what was there. Not triumph. Not relief, though relief was present. The specific feeling of having done what was needed to be done, of having been the right configuration of people in the right place at the right time, of the piece moving into its correct position in the larger structure that none of them could see all of at once but that the compass pointed toward, always, faithfully, toward whatever

came next.

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-- END OF VOLUME V --

NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER continues in:

Volume VI: Volume VI: The Second Great Battle